

## **Preface: The Weight of Three Nights**

For most of us, the story of the last week of Jesus is told in the colors of tradition: the palms of Sunday, the darkness of Friday, and the dawn of Sunday. We have inherited these markers from childhood. They are printed on our calendars, preached from our pulpits, and woven into the very fabric of our spring seasons.

Because these traditions are old, we assume they are accurate. Because they are universal, we assume they have been verified.

But there is a problem. It is a problem of simple math and specific words.

Jesus Christ gave one specific sign to validate His identity: the sign of the prophet Jonah. He stated, with absolute clarity, that He would be in the heart of the earth for "three days and three nights."

If we hold to the tradition of a Friday afternoon burial and a Sunday morning resurrection, the math fails. We find ourselves with two nights, not three. For centuries, we have been told to "reckon" our way around this—to accept that "part of a day" satisfies the requirement. But Jesus did not just say three days; He specified the nights.

This book is not an attempt to be "different" or "divisive." It is an attempt to be literal.

What follows is a study that sets aside the writings of men and the convenience of church tradition. It ignores the labels of "Palm Sunday" and "Good Friday" and "Sunday" to look at the actual time markers provided by Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John.

When we stop trying to force the Gospels into a Friday-to-Sunday window, a remarkable thing happens: the "friction" in the text disappears. The apparent contradictions between the women's purchase of spices and their preparation of them vanish. The legal requirements of the Hebrew feast days align perfectly with the events of the cross. And, perhaps most awe-inspiring of all, we discover that Jesus entered Jerusalem as the Lamb of God on the exact day the Law of Moses required the lamb to be chosen.

This study requires something of you: the willingness to follow the text wherever it leads, even if it leads you away from the traditions of a lifetime.

The tradition is old. But the text is older. It is time we let the text speak for itself.